Ram Vanji Sutar is an extreme case. At 99, he is probably the oldest practising sculptor anywhere. And if size were the true measure of a sculptor's merit, he would perhaps be considered the greatest. In our times, Ram Sutar is best known for his many truly enormous statues.

A Padma Bhushan awardee, Sutar was in the news once again when his 19-ft statue of B.R. Ambedkar was unveiled in Maryland in the US on October 14. Although it was Lilliputian by Sutar's otherwise Brobdingnagian standards, it was touted as the "largest" statue of the key architect of the Indian Constitution outside India. In 2018, Sutar became an international name as the creator of the Statue of Unity, the 597-ft bronze statue of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel in Gujarat. It is the world's tallest statue.

Since 1994, Sutar has worked in collaboration with his son, Anil Ram Sutar, who is qualified in architecture and urban design from Washington University in St Louis. The son does the maquettes now, but the father still supervises, making daily visits to the studio. The industry-scale studio and foundry on New Delhi's eastern outskirts is equipped with 3D scanners, robots, cranes and six CNC machines that cut thermocol to make monumental statues.

Sutar's works can be found all over the world. His Mahatma Gandhi statues are installed in 450 cities internationally. In an email interview, Sutar made a list of his own outstanding works: the Statue of Unity, the statue of Kempe Gowda at the Bengaluru International Airport, the 125-ft-high B.R. Ambedkar statue in Hyderabad, the 100-ft-high Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj statue at Pune. However,



STATE OF ART Ram V. Sutar showing photographs of the Chambal monument to Jawaharlal Nehru

DECADES AGO, JAWAHARLAL NEHRU HAD COMMISSIONED SUTAR TO CREATE A 50-FT BRONZE MONUMENT DEDICATED TO WORKERS WHO LAID DOWN THEIR LIVES TO BUILD THE BHAKRA NANGAL DAM. BUT THE PROJECT WAS SHELVED DUE TO PAUCITY OF FUNDS

EXHIBITION

PAINTING THE BLUES

*An ongoing show at the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, Noida—**Prussian Blue**—focuses on an iconic pigment that was discovered by accident but changed the course of art*



The story behind the genesis of the pigment Prussian blue is very much in the classic 'accidental discovery' template, à la Alexander Fleming and penicillin. Two German chemists circa 1704 were making Cochineal red, a pigment made from insects, when they accidentally used potash contaminated by the iron in the insects' blood, turning the solution a deep blue colour. Down the years, this affordable and versatile pigment has been used by noted artists around the world. At KNMA (Kiran Nadar Museum of Art), Noida, one can see several artworks involving this versatile pigment, in the show *Prussian Blue: A Serendipitous Colour that Altered the Trajectory of Art* (on till December 10). An impressive lineup of artists, including Anita Dube, Mithu Sen, Subodh Gupta, Ranbir Kaleka, Shilpa Gupta et al, have created works (paintings, sculptures, video art, installations) specifically commissioned for this show.

For instance, Anju Dodiya has created a pair of paintings, 'Sea-wind of the Night, I-II' (charcoal and water colour on fabric stretched on padded board), that incorporate a famous example of Prussian blue usage—Japanese woodcut artist Hokusai's iconic 'The Great Wave'. Ranbir Kaleka's *How far...?* (single channel video), which includes recordings of Bulgarian and Punjabi laments, connects the colour to climate change, epistemic violence and mass displacements of